

## Atlantic Ocean

*Spreading sea floor*



**Area** 29.7 million sq miles (77 million sq km)

**Average depth** 10,950 ft (3,926 m)

**Maximum depth** 28,230 ft (8,605 m) in Puerto Rico Trench

The Atlantic accounts for 29 percent of Earth's ocean area. It began forming 130 million years ago, and is still getting wider as the tectonic plate boundary that runs down its middle gradually pushes apart. The Atlantic is linked to the Mediterranean and

Baltic Seas in the east, and the Caribbean and Gulf of Mexico in the west.

### ▼ MIGRATING TURTLE

*This turtle migrates between the North Atlantic and its Caribbean nesting site.*



## Southern Ocean

*Frozen fringe*



**Area** 7.8 million sq miles (20 million sq km)

**Average depth** 14,763 ft (4,500 m)

**Maximum depth** 23,735 ft (7,235 m)

in South Sandwich Trench

Unlike the other oceans, this ocean has no real boundary, because its northern frontier is just a line of latitude on a map (60°S). It forms the fringe of ocean around Antarctica, and much of it freezes in winter. When the ice melts in summer, the water teems with new marine life, which provides a feast for animals such as the humpback whale above.

WATER



## Indian Ocean

*Tropical waters*



**Area** 26.5 million sq miles (69 million sq km)

**Average depth** 13,002 ft (3,963 m)

**Maximum depth** 23,812 ft (7,258 m) in Java Trench

The Indian Ocean lies between Africa, India, and Australia. Although its southern waters border the icy Southern Ocean, much of it is tropical, with coral reefs and

atolls like these in the Maldives near India. It is the warmest of the oceans, and its warmth generates many tropical storms during the summer months.



## Pacific Ocean

*Coral seas*



**Area** 60 million sq miles (156 million sq km)

**Average depth** 15,215 ft (4,028 m)

**Maximum depth** 35,840 ft (10,924 m)

in Mariana Trench

Although it is by far the largest ocean, the movement of Earth's tectonic plates means that the Pacific is shrinking at the same rate that the Atlantic is expanding. It is dotted with so many islands that they have been given the collective name Oceania. The coral reefs that fringe the South Pacific islands are famous for their rich marine life.



### ▲ DESERT ISLAND

*Many Pacific islands, like this one near Fiji, are uninhabited.*